

The Gandhi Pitch

The dynastic troika hardsells its prime ministerial candidate

SONIA ON MANMOHAN

"You have a choice to make. On one side you have a PM who is a man of integrity and on the other, a BJP leader who talks of fighting terror but you know what happened in his rule."

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



PRIYANKA ON MANMOHAN

"Take for example Mahatma Gandhi. No one was a gentler person than him but he was a great and strong leader. Manmohan Singh is a very strong, firm and capable leader."

AP PHOTO



RAHUL ON MANMOHAN

"Manmohan Singh is not a weak candidate, He is the Sher-e-Punjab and the pride of India. He has achieved a lot for the country and not buckled under terrorism."

AP PHOTO



"Judge me by my record, not by what Mr Advani says. The 'iron man' was quick to melt when held to fire during the Kandahar hijacking. We need a prime minister who is strong enough to act."

MANMOHAN ON HIMSELF



recession? That is the Congress's pitch to the electorate.

What exactly is Manmohanomics though? The good Doctor realised much earlier on that he would have to make a choice between Nehruvian socialism and his own image as a reformer. He chose the politically expedient course. After rolling back PSU disinvestments and endorsing reservations in private institutions, he can now make populist pledges with all the ease of a born again socialist. When asked how he reconciled his economics to the

Congress manifesto promise of 25 kg of rice or wheat to BPL families every month at Rs 3 a kg, he said, "If the foodgrains reach the poor, then the subsidy on food is not misspent and I don't grudge the expenditure."

Yet Brand Manmohan has limited appeal. So he is being marketed in centres that can understand his utility. While Sonia and Rahul fly to far-flung Dalit and tribal bastions where they meet the teeming masses and hug their children, Manmohan's itinerary takes him to South